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CURRENT THERAPEUTIC CHALLENGES IN THE TREATMENT OF PSORIASIS IN AYURVEDA

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ABSTRACT:

Psoriasis is an autoimmune skin disorder characterized by dry, scaly patches and inflammation, it is caused by environmental factors such as stress, and local injuries. According to auyrveda psoriasis occurs due to tridosha imbalance like vata, pitta and kapha, along with the involvement of raktadhatu and mamsadhatu. Psoriasis affect almost 2-5% of the people in the world. Treatment in Ayurveda always focus on whole body, because ayrveda always targate the root cause of the disease and fix it permanently. It involves Shodhana in which focus on removing the harmful waste and toxin out of the body, and Shamana which focus on reducing discomfort like pain or irritation and helps body to return in normal state. Modern medicine can give relief temporarily by reducing itching, swelling or redness in the body, it did not treat the root cause so the problem may return. And taking modern medicine for long time can shows some side effects. But Ayurveda always tries to understand what's going wrong inside our body, and aims to imbalances inside the body and cleaning it, so the problem can reduce from its root rather than treating it for short time. This review talks about the challenges and difficulties that doctors and researchers may face when treat Psoriasis using Ayurveda. It explains the challenges in the treatment of psoriasis in Ayurveda, due to some reasons such as, sometime doctors may not treat the disease in the same way, herbal medicines are not follows the same uniform standards, patients sometime don't follow the treatment properly, the result can take time to shows its effect.

Keywords: *Psoriasis, Skin disorder, Ayurveda, Shodhana, Shamana, Raktadhatu.*

Introduction:

Psoriasis is an auto immune skin related problem, happens when the body defence system reacts unusual making skin cells build up too quickly. Things like feeling stressed, sudden climate changes, or small cuts, scratches or skin injuries can make it worse.

According to Ayurveda Psoriasis happens when the natural balance of the body may disturbed and disturbance in three doshas, such as vata, pitta and kapha. It also affect the blood (Rakta Dhatu) and muscle tissue (Mamsa Dhatu). According to this system, the condition is treated in a complete way using Sodhana therapy, which helps in cleansing the body, and Shamana therapy, which helps in controlling and soothing the symptoms("Ayurvedic Approach in the Successful Management of Psoriasis," n.d.). Psoriasis happens when the body's immune system reacts in an abnormal way, which leads to faster growth of inflamed skin cells and causes patches on the skin. This condition has been known for many years, but its exact cause and complete treatment are still not fully understood.

In Ayurveda, many herbs are found useful in managing psoriasis. However, since the disease has many causes and affects the body in different ways, it usually needs a combined or multi-level treatment approach for better results(Nille & Chaudhary, 2021). Scaly red plaques are the main symptom of psoriasis, an immune-mediated, chronic, relapsing inflammatory skin condition. It can impact the joints and is frequently linked to other multi-system conditions like metabolic syndrome, digestive system disorders, and cardiovascular system disorders.1-3 Patients' quality of life is significantly impacted by psoriasis, which can appear at any age(Gu et al., 2025).

Males are twice as likely as females to be afflicted, and it typically affects people in their third or fourth decade of life. Patients with psoriasis experience severe physical, mental, and social burdens as a result of the disease's substantial negative effects on their quality of life and those of their family. The WHO's most current Global Report on Psoriasis2 highlights the numerous unresolved research gaps in psoriasis, covering topics like epidemiology, aetiology, comorbidity association, treatment, and strategies to enhance healthcare systems(Thappa & Munisamy, 2017).

Psoriasis is a common, serious, inflammatory, chronic disease that has a significant impact on healthcare systems all over the world(Damiani et al., 2021).

Global studies show that psoriasis is not equally common everywhere. The number of cases changes a lot from one region to another. For example, in East Asia the rate is very low (around 0.14%), while in places like Australasia it is much higher (about 1.99%).

Even though we have some information, there are still major gaps in understanding the disease. In many countries, proper data about how many new cases occur and how it affects different age groups is missing. In fact, nearly 76% of countries do not have proper records or studies on psoriasis(Li et al., 2025).

Geographical location, age, and other factors can affect the incidence and prevalence of psoriasis. Psoriasis affected 2.3% of people worldwide, with the highest prevalence rates found in North America and Europe. Additionally, the study found that psoriasis prevalence increased with age, reaching a high in those 60 years of age and beyond. It was also shown that psoriasis is more common in men than in women(Armstrong et al., 2017).

The incidence rates for males and women are 85.5:73.2 per 100,000 person-years, A population-based study conducted in 2015 found that there are 98 cases of psoriasis for every 100,000 person-years in the US(Chakith M R et al., 2025).

In Ayurveda, one type of kushtha called Kitibha Kushtha is quite similar to plaque psoriasis. In psoriasis the skin become red, dry, rough and scaly. The colour of the skin become darker than normal and a lot of itching happens. In modern medical practices, doctors use a scoring system called PASI (Psoriasis Area and Severity Index). This helps to measure the redness, thickness, and scaling of the skin patches, also how much the body is affected. The score is normally between 0 to 72, The score defines about the condition higher the score, more severe the condition(Gujjar et al., 2025).

Ayurvedic Perspective on Dosha Imbalance and Psoriasis:

In Psoriasis, Ayurveda says that mainly two doshas get disturbed, the first vata which cause dryness, roughness and scaling the skin, and the other Kapha which leads to itching, thicker the skin and silvery scales forming on the skin. In Ayurveda, this condition can affect Skin (Twacha), Blood (Rakta) and sometimes Muscles (Mamsa). When there is imbalance in the body and toxins (Ama) starts building up, it can lead to patchy, dry and scaly skin problem.

The body channels (Srotas), especially those related to blood (Raktavaha) and skin (Twakvaha), get blocked due to Ama (toxins), which happens due to wrong eating habits and unhealthy lifestyle.

Common causes include cold and dry weather, eating wrong food combinations, irregular daily routine and stress. All these make the condition worse.

In Ayurveda, treatment focuses on correcting diet and lifestyle to balance the doshas. It also includes cleaning the blood and improving digestion and metabolism. Therapies like Virechana (purgation) and Rakta Mokshana (blood purification) are often used.

Some helpful herbs are Haridra (turmeric), Neem, Guduchi and Manjistha. These help reduce inflammation, remove toxins, improve immunity and purify blood.

Diet should avoid foods that increase Vata and Kapha, like curd, seafood, very sour and salty items. Instead, fresh, warm and simple food should be taken regularly.

Lifestyle changes like daily exercise, yoga and proper sleep are also important to reduce stress and manage the condition better.

Overall, Ayurveda focuses on a balanced approach of diet, lifestyle and treatment to control and prevent this long-term skin problem(Hazra et al., 2017)(Chinthala et al., 2020).

Modern medicine mainly helps control symptoms and supports the immune system, while Ayurveda focuses on treating the root cause by cleaning toxins from the body and balancing metabolism(GITIKA et al., 2025).

Methodology:

Literature Review:

A comprehensive review of Ayurvedic classical texts, modern dermatology research papers, and clinical trial reports was conducted.

Data Sources:

This study was compiled using data obtained from online scientific databases such as PubMed, Google Scholar, Springer, Wiley Online library, sciencedirect, ResearchGate and Ayurvedic texts such as Charaka Samhita.

Ayurvedic Treatment Methods

Shodhana (Body cleansing treatments)

This includes Panchakarma therapies like:

i.Vamana (controlled vomiting to remove toxins)

ii. Virechana (cleansing through purgation)

iii. RaktaMokshana (removal or purification of blood)

iv. TakraDhara is another therapy where medicated buttermilk is gently poured over the body or forehead to give a cooling and soothing effect.

Shamana (Relief and balancing treatments)

This focuses on calming the condition using herbal medicines like Neem, Haldi (turmeric), Manjistha, Guduchi and Khadir, which help in reducing symptoms and improving overall balance.

External use: Applying herbal pastes (Lepas) and medicated oils on the skin, such as Jatyadi Taila and Mahamarichyadi Taila.

Diet changes: Avoid wrong food combinations and try to include more bitter and cooling foods in your meals.

Yoga and meditation: Doing practices like Pranayama and simple mindfulness helps reduce stress and supports better control of the condition("Eka Kustha (Psoriasis)- A Comprehensive Review of Ayurvedic and Modern Approaches," n.d.).

Modern Treatment for Psoriasis

Medicines used:

Topical treatments (applied on skin):

Creams and ointments like corticosteroids, Vitamin D medicines such as Calcipotriol, and calcineurin inhibitors are commonly used.

Systemic medicines (taken orally or by injection):

For severe cases, doctors may give medicines like Methotrexate, Cyclosporine and Acitretin.

Newer Medicines:

Some newer drugs like Apremilast (PDE4 inhibitor) and Tofacitinib (JAK inhibitor) are now being used more as they help in better control of the disease(Liu et al., 2021).

Biological Treatments:

These are advanced medicines used for better control of psoriasis:

i. TNF-alpha blockers: Medicines like Infliximab, Etanercept and Adalimumab help reduce inflammation in the body.

ii. IL-17 / IL-23 blockers: Drugs such as Secukinumab, Ustekinumab and Guselkumab target specific parts of the immune system.
iii. JAK inhibitors: Medicines like Tofacitinib are also being used and are showing good results.
iv. Precision medicine: New research is focusing on treatments based on a person's genes, so that therapy can be more targeted and effective(Majeed et al., 2021).

Phototherapy (light treatment):

i. Narrowband UVB therapy: Uses a special type of UV light to reduce skin inflammation and slow down fast skin cell growth.
ii. PUVA therapy: In this, a medicine called psoralen is given along with UVA light treatment to improve the condition.
iii. Excimer laser therapy: This is a more targeted light treatment that works on specific affected areas and usually has fewer side effects(Khojah et al., 2021).

Challenges in the Treatment of Psoriasis:

Psoriasis can be managed with different treatments in Ayurveda, but it is not always simple and comes with some difficulties. One of the major issue is every patients body type (Prakriti) is different and condition is also different, so the same treatment may not work equally well for everyone. In some cases, psoriasis could not go completely or it may come back again if proper care is not followed, due to this people feels discomfort(Lee & Kim, 2023).

Another challenge in ayuvedic treatment is it works slowly because it focus on root cause of the disease. If focus on balancing digestion removing toxin which need regular follow up which some time create problem for the patients due to lack of time.
In ayurvedic treatment patients need to follow disciplined diet also they have to avoid some foods, follow strict routine. And this is hard for some patients to follow these routines and foods restrictions which can reduce the effectiveness of the treatment(Rammanohar, 2019).
Sometime combining ayurvedic treatment and modern treatment can be confusing without proper medical guidance. So, consulting with experienced ayurvedic doctor is important for effective result.

Sometime treatment may be costly and also takes time which for those patients who need regular check-up and care(Kothapalli et al., 2026).

One of the positive thing of Ayurveda is it has been used for long time in managing skin disease like psoriasis. Ayurvedic treatment not only reduces the symptoms it also focus on root cause by balancing body doshas, detoxifying it and improving immunity. This holistic approach helps in long-term management and reducing chances of recurrence(Srivastava et al., 2024)

Conclusion:

Both ayurvedic and modern treatment plays important role in the treatment of psoriasis. Modern treatment gives instant relive form symptoms, but ayurvedic treatment always focus on root cause of the disease.

By combining both modern and ayurvedic treatment sometimes shows a better result. Because ayurvedic treatment detox the body change diet also change the life style and modern medicine gives quick relives. In future more studies and clinical trials are required for combining modern and ayurvedic treatment for better results and quick relives.

By the advancement of genetic research and personalised medicine ayurveda become more effective and these challenges in the treatment of psoriasis can be reduced, and the discomfort of the patients and long term treatment also reduces. And the treatment becomes more effective.

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